Since the vast majority of the surviving structures in the region appear to have been intended for defense and surveillance, scholars have interpreted it as the stage for continual skirmishes and close-quarter battles. Such a picture of historical Ghur was first painted by Bosworth (see also Chapter 1), *viz.* an isolated and politically fragmented region of "fortified domesticity" whose internally squabbling inhabitants repelled outsiders throughout historical memory.[34] Furthermore, modern studies have accepted at face value Juzjani's assertion that 'Abbas ibn Shish (early–mid-eleventh century), a scion of the rival Shishani lineage (also collateral to the pre-imperial Shansabanis), built the fortifications still standing in central–southern Ghur, thereby dating them to a short period probably sometime in the first half of the eleventh century.[35] Indeed, this domino effect of accepted assumptions appears to have resulted in a focus largely on defensive structures in southern Ghur. Ball, for example, explained an apparent concentration of defense and surveillance structures in Ghur's southern reaches as the Shansabanis' principal line of defense against the Ghaznavids, necessitated by the latter's vast empire and particularly their presence in the contiguous area of Bust-Lashkari Bazar during the eleventh century.[36]

However, a much-needed re-examination of central Ghur's built environment is undertaken here, encompassing the typologies, and decorative styles and iconographies of the built remains themselves. It is equally important to bring to bear upon the analysis what is known of the lifestyles and economies of the pre-imperial Shansabanis and their fellow Ghuris. I point to the possibility of an alternative time span of construction for at least *some* of southern Ghur's standing structures: the late or post-Sasanian through early Islamic (seventh–tenth centuries) periods,[37] which would thereby pre-date the Shansabanis and their immediate forebears. Additionally, the documented traces of decoration on some of Ghur's architectural remains plausibly suggest non-defensive functions for them as well. These new possibilities for understanding Ghur's architectural landscape are not only supported by the architectural evidence, they also fit better into the *more* nomadic/transhumant lifestyles of the Shansabanis' pre-imperial ancestors. But, as ever, it must be remembered that the ensuing analyses and conclusions remain tentative, based on the documentation of scholars working in the region through the late 1970s when it was more accessible.

It was noted above that Ghur's built remains comprise either walled enclosures with integrated square or semi-circular corner bastions, or individual "dwelling towers,"[38] the latter being more common (Figures 2.6–2.8). The construction materials were locally sourced and consisted primarily of sun-dried bricks, which formed walls atop stone footings varying in height (Figure 2.9). Some variation in brick sizes was also observed, ranging from 33 cm to 48 cm in length and 8 cm to 11 cm in